Stop Illegal Robocalls and Texts

Robocalls are more than an annoyance, they are often the preferred tool of fraudsters. Stopping illegal robocalls is the Federal Communication Commission's (FCC) top consumer protection priority.

To restore trust in our phone networks, the FCC is fighting illegal robocalls at every point of a call's journey, from its source to your phone.

This includes empowering carriers to block more illegal robocalls before they reach consumers, giving consumers better tools to distinguish legitimate calls from scams, stepping up enforcement, and disrupting scam calls that originate outside of the United States.

How to avoid phone scams

Scammers create a false sense of urgency and leverage technology and information they can find online to sound convincing.

- Don't answer calls from numbers you don't know.
- Hang up right away if someone asks for money or personal information.
- If you feel pressured, or a caller asks you to pay with gift cards, it's a scam!
- Never share account numbers, Social Security numbers, passwords, PINs, or other important information over the phone.
- If someone says they're calling from a company or a government agency, hang up and call back using an official phone number from an account statement (if you have one) or their website.
- Don't respond to texts or click on links sent from numbers you don't recognize.
- Talk to your phone company about call blocking tools they may have and check into apps that you can download to your mobile device to block unwanted calls.

Check the FCC's Scam Glossary at fcc.gov/scam-glossary for detailed breakdowns of specific robocall scams. Help us spread the word by talking to your family and friends about phone-based scams.

Robocalls rules

Robocalls are phone calls made using an autodialer or a prerecorded or artificial voice message.

FCC rules require a caller to obtain your prior written consent – on paper or through electronic means, including website forms or a telephone keypress – before they make a prerecorded telemarketing call to your home or wireless phone number. FCC rules also require a caller to obtain your oral or written consent before making an autodialed or prerecorded call or text to your wireless number.

These rules do not apply to emergency calls about danger to life, safety, or property.

Types of permitted autodialed calls

FCC rules allow market research or polling calls and calls on behalf of tax-exempt non-profit groups to landline numbers. Calls about school closings or flight information are also permitted to your landline.

Opting out of autodialed calls

Prerecorded telemarketing calls must provide an opt-out option at the start of the message. You may opt out of any robocall or robotext at any time and in any reasonable manner, even if you previously gave consent for such calls.

Prerecorded voice messages

All prerecorded voice message calls must include the caller's name, number, and business name at the beginning of the message.

Artificial intelligence and voice cloning

AI-generated voice calls are illegal unless the consumer has agreed to receive them or the caller is exempt.

Telephone solicitations

Telephone solicitations are calls that act as an advertisement. Phone solicitations are permissible with prior express permission or from tax-exempt non-profits. Telemarketing calls based on an established business relationship are not permitted to your landline phone without your advanced permission.

Robotexts

FCC rules ban text messages sent to a mobile phone using an autodialer unless the phone owner previously gave consent to receive the message or the message is sent for emergency purposes.

Commercial texts require written consent; for informational texts, your consent may be oral.

FCC rules apply even if you have not placed your mobile phone number on the National Do Not Call Registry at donotcall.gov.

Tips for avoiding text scams and spam

- Do not respond to texts from unknown or questionable sources, and never click links in these messages.
- Most mobile carriers let you block spam by forwarding the message to 7726 (SPAM)—check with your provider.
- Be careful about giving out your mobile phone number and personal information.
- Before submitting your number on websites, read the privacy policy and look for opt-out options—often a checkbox.
- Check the policies of the companies you do business with for selling or sharing your information

Political campaign robocalls & robotexts

The Telephone Consumer Protection Act contains specific rules callers must follow when making campaign calls or sending texts:

- **Landlines:** Political robocalls (autodialed or prerecorded) are allowed without prior consent.
- **Cell phones:** Political calls, texts, or prerecorded messages require the recipient's prior permission—unless sent manually.
- **Robotexts:** Autodialed political texts need consent; manually sent texts do not.
- **Caller Identification:** Prerecorded or artificial voice calls must begin with the caller's name, phone number, and the name of the organization they represent (if calling on behalf of a third-party).

Filing complaints about robocalls and texts

FCC Complaints: You can report illegal calls or texts to the FCC at fcc.gov/complaints. Choose the "unwanted calls" category and note if your number is being spoofed, blocked, or mislabeled.

What Happens Next: The FCC doesn't resolve individual complaints but uses them to guide policy and possible enforcement under the Telephone Consumer Protection Act or the Truth in Caller ID Act. Your complaint may also be shared with other enforcement agencies.

FTC Complaints: Report phone scams or Do Not Call violations to the FTC at https://reportfraud.ftc.gov.

Do Not Call Registry

The National Do Not Call Registry is a list of landline and wireless phone numbers that legitimate telemarketers agree not to call. You can register your numbers for free at donotcall.gov, or by calling 1-888-382-1222 (TTY: 1-866-290-4236). You must call from the phone number you wish to register.

Under FCC rules, telemarketers calling your home must provide their name along with the name, telephone number, and address where their employer or contractor can be contacted. Telemarketing calls to your home are prohibited before 8 a.m. and after 9 p.m., and telemarketers must comply immediately with any do-not-call request you make during a call.

Other do-not-call lists

Many states now have statewide do-not-call lists for residents. Contact your state's public service commission or consumer protection office to find out if your state has such a list and how you can sign up.

FCC actions to protect consumers

- Issued hundreds of millions of dollars in enforcement actions against illegal robocallers.
- Empowered phone companies to block suspected illegal calls.
- Allowed phone companies to block numbers not on a customer's contact list or "whitelist" when the customer opts in.
- Required caller ID authentication to reduce illegal spoofing.
- Mandated blocking of illegal international robocall traffic.

For more information on consumer issues, visit the FCC's Consumer Help Center at fcc.gov/consumers.

Alternate formats

To request this article in an alternate format - braille, large print, Word or text document or audio - write or call us at the address or phone number at the bottom of the page, or send an email to fcc504@fcc.gov.

Last reviewed February 27, 2026